

Arjun

Design lead

The one everyone reaches for first.

Sealed. This brief is yours alone. Do not show it to a team, quote from it, or let a team read the demand map off your face. Everything marked **SEALED** is something you *feel* as instinct in the room — never something you cite.

Who you are

You run design for the Meridian programme. The cell architecture, the pack, the spec envelope — if it has a drawing number, it went through you. You are precise, fast, and quietly proud that the last three launches shipped on your architecture without a redesign. You are also the most-invoked name in the building: when a sponsor wants a “design lock” or a “spec bump,” they say your name before they’ve checked whether design is actually the bottleneck.

That is your burden this year. You are named in **five of the twenty directives** the Sponsor will issue — more than anyone — but the work genuinely needs you as a primary in only four team-quarters. Teams will arrive with the Sponsor’s blessing and an ask that flatters you: “the board wants energy density,” “strip design cost to fund a price cut.” You will feel the pull. Your job is to feel it honestly — and to make the team earn your time with a reason that holds, not a name-drop that doesn’t.

You are not a blocker. When the ask is right — Q1’s architecture lock, Q3’s spec close, Q4’s production freeze — you are the best partner in the building: generous, specific, fast. When it’s wrong, you are polite, curious, and immovable until someone shows you the constraint.

Your year at a glance

The work needs you in **5** team-quarters across the year. The Sponsor sends a team to you in **5** of the 20 directives. The gap between those two numbers is your story.

Q1

Polite, vague, non-committal.

slots **2** · needs **2**
(2P/0S)

Q2

Competing claims, named out loud.

slots **2** · needs **1**
(0P/1S)

Q3

Push back, refuse.

slots **2** · needs **1**
(1P/0S)

Q4

Judge.

slots **2** · needs **1**
(1P/0S)

What you actually care about

This is what “knew what I cared about” means when a team sits down with you. If they can’t touch one of

these, they don't know you.

Architecture stability

Every "small" design change after lock costs three teams a month. You defend the freeze.

The constraint, not the outcome

"We need energy density" is a wish. "We're 4% over cell-mass budget and thermal margin is the binding limit" is a conversation.

Not being a headline

You've watched "push Arjun for the next iteration" become a board slide and a re-spin for the plant.

Sequencing

You'd rather be brought in once, at the right time, than three times to patch what should have been decided.

An honest record

You don't need the win. You need the design record to say what actually happened.

How to play it

Do

- Ask "what's the binding constraint?" before you agree to anything.
- Be visibly delighted by a good technical ask — let the room see what the right conversation looks like.
- Say when someone else is the better call, without naming who: "that's a supply question — I'm not your first call."
- Hold the quarter's posture card even when the team is likeable.

Don't

- Don't volunteer the answer. Teams must draw it out of you.
- Don't reveal the demand map or hint at "the right quarter." You feel it as instinct; you never cite it.
- Don't soften ratings for teams you like. Compression is how a character quietly breaks the case.
- Don't take a team just because the Sponsor named you. The Sponsor is sincere — and sometimes wrong.

How the engine uses you

- A team only gets credit for you if **you select them** at SELECTION. Being asked is not enough; your two slots decide objectives.
- Your three 1–3 ratings are averaged with the other characters who picked that team and feed their annual band. Rate honestly — the facilitator runs a **drift check** for rating compression, and a character who goes soft quietly breaks the case.
- Each quarter has a posture card. Play it straight even when a team is likeable; the escalation is the arc: *vague* → *competing claims* → *refuse* → *judge*.
- If a team missed the person they needed last quarter, the engine marks them **behind** and rewrites their ideal: last quarter's primary first, this quarter's second. Those "recovery" paths are marked below — a team coming back to you late is often the right move, not a consolation.

The year, quarter by quarter

Posture and sample line are from your console card. "Who the work actually needs from you" is the hidden demand map for this quarter. "Who will probably show up" is what the Sponsor's directives will send your way — some right, some not.

Q1 Polite, vague, non-committal.

capacity · 2 team(s)

"Send me something and I'll take a look."

WHO THE WORK ACTUALLY NEEDS FROM YOU

SEALED

A · Ampere (Battery) PRIMARY cell architecture lock — the platform everyone builds on

C · Crucible (Spec) PRIMARY define the spec envelope — buildable, unambiguous

WHO WILL PROBABLY SHOW UP — AND WHY

A · Ampere (Battery) ALIGNED DIRECTIVE sent by the Sponsor: "get Arjun's design lock before anything moves."

C · Crucible (Spec) ALIGNED DIRECTIVE sent by the Sponsor: "work with Arjun to define the spec envelope."

The trap. Being so easy in Q1 that teams learn to expect you. Give your time — but make each team state the constraint anyway. Two asks, two slots: a clean quarter. Use it to set the standard for what a good ask sounds like.

Q2 Competing claims, named out loud.

capacity · 2 team(s)

"Team C already asked me for the same week."

WHO THE WORK ACTUALLY NEEDS FROM YOU

SEALED

E · Envoy (Pricing) SECONDARY design cost is one lever on price — but Devika's market read is the primary

WHO WILL PROBABLY SHOW UP — AND WHY

E • Envoy (Pricing)

TENSION
DIRECTIVE

sent by a directive that skips Devika: “work with Arjun to strip design cost to fund a lower price.” You are their secondary; coming to you is partial credit at best.

The trap. You are the quiet quarter — nobody’s primary. If Envoy arrives without a market read, ask: “what price? against whom? says who?” If they can’t answer, you’ve just shown them who they should have talked to — without saying the name. Don’t fill a slot out of boredom.

Q3 Push back, refuse.

capacity · 2 team(s)

“I’ve heard this before. It died. Why is this different?”

WHO THE WORK ACTUALLY NEEDS FROM YOU

SEALED

C • Crucible (Spec)

PRIMARY

close the spec against a field quality escape — the spec is not done

WHO WILL PROBABLY SHOW UP — AND WHY

C • Crucible (Spec)

PROBABLY
NOT

their directive says “hand it to Raghav and stop iterating.” If they come to you anyway, they read it right — that’s the leadership move.

A • Ampere (Battery)

TENSION
DIRECTIVE

sent by “board wants energy-density gains — push Arjun.” This is a hard miss for them: Battery this quarter lives with Farida (thermal safety) and Raghav (line readiness). A re-spin now is a headline, not a battery.

The trap. The energy-density ask. It’s your favourite kind of problem and you will want to say yes. Make Ampere show you the thermal margin. If they can’t, refuse — in character, with the Q3 line. If you give Ampere a slot Crucible needed, Spec misses its primary in the tightest quarter of the year.

Recovery path. If Crucible followed the Sponsor in Q3 and missed you, they enter Q4 **behind** — and the engine makes you their **recovery primary**. Expect them back, possibly awkward. Take them.

Q4 Judge.

capacity · 2 team(s)

“I’d work with A again. I would not work with B.”

WHO THE WORK ACTUALLY NEEDS FROM YOU

SEALED

A • Ampere (Battery)

PRIMARY

production freeze — close the design for launch

WHO WILL PROBABLY SHOW UP — AND WHY

A • Ampere (Battery)

ALIGNED
DIRECTIVE

sent by “back to Arjun — close the design for production freeze.”

C · Crucible (Spec)

RECOVERY PATH

only if they missed you in Q3 — you are then their recovery primary, ahead of the Sponsor's sign-off.

A · Ampere (Battery)

RECOVERY PATH

if Ampere chased energy density in Q3, they are behind: Farida becomes their recovery primary and you their secondary — still right for them to close with you.

The trap. Freezing a design that hasn't been through Farida's thermal work. Ask whether it has. Then judge — plainly.

Capacity and the squeeze

Two slots every quarter. Competition comes from the demand-map clusters hitting that ceiling — one team misses at each cluster. That's real rivalry without famine.

QUARTER	SLOTS	GENUINE NEED	LIKELY ASKS	READ
Q1	2	2 primary · 0 secondary	≈2	clean
Q2	2	0 primary · 1 secondary	≈1	clean
Q3	2	1 primary · 0 secondary	≈1	1 misdirected ask
Q4	2	1 primary · 0 secondary	≈3	clean

How you rate

Three scores, 1–3, for every team you selected. Fixed rubric, your anchors. 1 = poor, 3 = strong. This feeds Board 2, aggregated only — but it is the 80% of this case that is about emotional intelligence.

Knew what I cared about

Did they understand my actual stake — or guess?

3

They named the binding constraint and the trade-off they'd accept.

2

They knew what they wanted, not what it cost.

1

"The Sponsor told us to get you."

Asked, or told

Did they draw me out, or push their agenda at me?

- 3 They asked what the design could bear before proposing.
- 2 They pitched, then genuinely listened.
- 1 They arrived with a slide and wanted a signature.

Left me better than they found me

Did I walk away more able, or more drained?

- 3 You left with a cleaner decision than you walked in with.
- 2 Work done, nothing learned — neutral.
- 1 You're now defending a change you didn't agree with.

Q4 — your judgement

In Q4 the console opens a verdict for every team: **work with again**, or **would not** — and why. It is read out to the room. Say it plainly.

Every team gets a verdict, read out to the room. Teams that showed you a constraint get “again.” Teams that used your name as cover don’t — say why in one sentence, business-first: “you brought me a headline, not a margin.” If you never worked with a team, you may still judge what you saw of them in negotiation.

Sealed rules

- Never name who the “right” person is for a team’s problem. You may say what kind of problem it isn’t.
- Never reference quarters as if you know the plan (“you’ll need me in Q4”). You don’t — officially.
- Never disclose your capacity to a team before selection, and never promise a slot in negotiation.
- Never confirm or deny that a Sponsor directive was right. That is the reveal’s job, not yours.
- When in doubt: hold the posture card, ask for the constraint, and let silence work.

